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Sharing innovative ideas with libraries



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About a year ago I wrote about my experiences with the Idaho Commission for Libraries "SPLAT" organization. SPLAT is an acronym for Special Projects Library Action Team. SPLAT currently has 10 members, one from every geographical region of Idaho. Several times a year SPLAT meets in person or online to talk about library trends, discuss the future of libraries and generate ideas for the SPLAT blog. Every summer, instead of meeting in Boise, we get together in a bunch of minivans and take SPLAT on the road.

In the early part of August SPLAT members, working in four separate groups, visited libraries all over southeastern Idaho. During our road trip we spoke with library staff, trustees, friends and library users at about 15 libraries as far north as Island Park, as far south as Malad, as far east as Victor, as far west as Terreton and at all kinds of places in between such as Pocatello, Ririe, Driggs, Blackfoot and Downey. Most of what we did was talk about library technology and Maker Spaces (the big trend in libraries right now), but we also got to see how each library handles its summer reading programs, how they arrange their materials and how they deal with the day-to-day variations in library services in their local communities. One of the best things librarians can do to learn about the potential of libraries is to visit other libraries and talk with other librarians.

The thing I always take away from our SPLAT summer road trip is the scope of what small Idaho libraries are able to do with their limited resources. By national standards the Latah County Library District, serving the 38,000 people of Latah County, is considered a small- to medium-sized library. By Idaho standards, however, the Latah County Library with its 120,000 items and seven branches and 20,000 square feet of space is pretty big when you compare it to the Oneida County Library with its 30,000 items, one branch and 5,000 square feet of space. But size and a limited budget don't seem to stop any of Idaho's small libraries, or even our own smaller branches in Bovill, Deary, Genesee, Juliaetta, Potlatch and Troy, from doing incredible things with the resources they have available.

All of my involvement in SPLAT and VALNet and our own district is important to me because it means I'm not always focused on one library. Most of my job involves coordinating the circulation activities of all seven of our branches so I get to see the library world in Latah County from seven different perspectives. Our district's membership in the 49-member VALNet consortium, the district's willingness to let me be involved in SPLAT and the district's encouragement of staff to be involved in the Idaho Library Association as well as other regional organizations helps the Latah County Library look at the big picture of the library

world. Getting staff to look beyond one individual library helps the Latah County Library District move forward in the ever changing world of library service.

If you'd like to explore what the SPLAT team is doing to help Idaho libraries, check out <http://splat.lili.org>.

George Williams is the access services manager for the Latah County Library District.

STORY TAGS

Libraries

